

John Locke and the Truth about “True and Saving Religion”

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He that makes use of the Light and Faculties GOD has given him, and seeks sincerely to discover Truth, by those Helps and Abilities he has, may have this satisfaction in doing his Duty as a rational Creature, that though he should miss the Truth, he will not miss the Reward of it¹

[There are some t]hings seeming little, and inconsiderable in themselves whose consequences & tendency may be very great²

This article refutes “a very old opinion.” For upwards of a century, commentators have traced the “liberal insistence that religion is a private affair” back to John Locke’s *Letter concerning Toleration*.³ The hindsight view is that this classic text advocated “the liberal privatization of

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In memoriam: Michael Stanton (1939–2024), a far more accomplished Latinist than the author. “Ecce mysterium vobis dico: omnes quidem resurgemus, sed non omnes immutabimur. In momento, in ictu oculi, in novissima tuba: canet enim tuba, et mortui resurgent incorrupti: et nos immutabimur” 1 Cor. 15: 51–52.

1 John Locke, *An Essay concerning Human Understanding*, ed. Peter H. Nidditch (Clarendon Press, 1975), IV. xvii. 24, 688.

2 John Locke, “The Nature of Churches,” [1681–2] Bodleian Library, MS. Locke c. 34, p. 1. Untitled and undated notes and reflections on Edward Stillingfleet’s *The Mischief of Separation* (London, 1680) and *The Unreasonableness of Separation* (London, 1681). The manuscript is preponderantly in the handwriting of Locke’s friend James Tyrrell, who acted as his “operator”—that is to say, performed the mechanical operation of writing to Locke’s dictation. See Locke to Edward Clarke, 26 March/5 April 1685, no. 817, in *The Correspondence of John Locke*, ed. E. S. de Beer and Mark Goldie (9 vols., Oxford: Clarendon Press: 1976–2023), 2:709, and compare *OED*, operator, *n.* 1 a. In 1686 Tyrrell urged Locke to “perfect” out of these notes “your intended discourse concerning Toleration, and Persecution.” See James Tyrrell to Locke, 26 December [1686], no. 889, in Locke, *Correspondence*, 3:92. The complete text will shortly be published with ancillary material in John Locke: *The Nature of Churches, and Other Writings on Politics and Religion 1667–1682*, ed. Timothy Stanton (Clarendon Press, forthcoming.) Tyrrell’s life and career are discussed in Julia Rudolph, *Revolution by Degrees: James Tyrrell and Whig Political Thought in the Late Seventeenth Century* (Basingstoke, 2002). Latterly he became embittered towards Locke and was the source of an unflattering memoir of his life recorded by Pierre Des Maizeaux in 1718–19. See Felix Waldmann, “John Locke as a Reader of Thomas Hobbes’s *Leviathan*: A New Manuscript,” *The Journal of Modern History* 93 (2021): 245–282.

3 See J. Brian Benestad, *Church, State, and Society: An Introduction to Catholic Social Doctrine* (Catholic University of America Press, 2011), 427.

religion.”⁴ This remains the prevalent view. It receives powerful confirmation from the Lockean postulate—amongst the most quoted phrases in his entire corpus—that “true and saving religion consists in an inward perswasion of the mind.”⁵ The effect of this postulate—hereafter “the postulate”—is to make religion the stuff of opinion, belief, or preference and, as such, something private and optional.⁶

The postulate is likewise adduced as evidence that Locke’s principal purpose in the *Letter* was to defend “the individual’s conscience.”⁷ It encapsulates *in nuce* “liberalism’s religion”⁸: a religion without a church, a special revelation, or any particular God, in which the means of salvation are construed simply in terms of the freedom of the individual to choose which subjective beliefs to adopt.⁹ It casts Locke in the role of inventor and exponent of a distinction between public and private—a sphere of external action regulated by government and an internal arena belonging to individuals.¹⁰

4 Mark Goldie, “The Civil Religion of James Harrington,” in *The Languages of Political Theory in Early Modern Europe*, ed. Anthony Pagden (Cambridge University Press, 1987), 197–222, at 202.

5 John Locke, *A Letter concerning Toleration*, ed. James Tully (Hackett, 1983), 27.

6 David Alvarez, “Reading Locke after Shaftesbury: Feeling our Way towards a Postsecular Genealogy of Religious Belief”, in *Mind, Body, Motion, Matter: Eighteenth-Century British and French Literary Perspectives*, ed. Mary Helen McMurrin and Alison Conway (University of Toronto Press, 2016), 72–109, at 92.

7 Richard Ashcraft, *Revolutionary Politics & Locke’s Two Treatises of Government* (Princeton University Press, 1986), 499.

8 Cecile Laborde, *Liberalism’s Religion* (Harvard University Press, 2017), esp. 3–20.

9 George Kateb, “Locke and the Political Origins of Secularism,” *Social Research* 76 (2009): 1001–1034, at 1022.

10 See e.g. G. A. J. Rogers, “The Limit of State Authority: John Locke and the Invention of the Private,” in *Dal Necessario al Possibile: Determinismo e Libertà nel Pensiero Anglo-Olandese del XVII Secolo*, ed. Luisa Simonutti (Franco Angeli, 1998), 99–115; Ronald Beiner, *Civil Religion: A Dialogue in the History of Political Philosophy* (Cambridge University Press, 2011), 151; Eric R. Claeys, “The Private Society and the Liberal Public Good in John Locke’s Thought,” *Social Philosophy and Policy* 25 (2008): 201–234, esp. 212–213; Ingrid Creppell, “Locke on Toleration: The Transformation of Constraint,” *Political Theory* 24 (1996): 200–240, at 225; Jean Bethke Elshtain, *Public Man, Private Woman: Women in Social and Political Thought* (Princeton University Press, 1981), 118–126; John Locke, *An Essay concerning Toleration, and Other Writings on Law and Politics, 1667–1683*, ed. J. R. Milton and Philip Milton (Clarendon Press, 2006), 32; Lee Ward, *John Locke and Modern Life* (Cambridge University Press, 2010), 99, 249; Adam Wolfson, *Persecution or Toleration: An Exposition of the Locke–Proast Quarrel, 1689–1704* (Lexington Books, 2010), 37; David Wootton, *John Locke: Political Writings* (Hackett, 2003), 104–5.

This view remains a commonplace amongst scholars in many different disciplines: historians of ideas, philosophers, and political theorists alike. So too the perception that Locke used this distinction to remove religion from the public sphere and to “radically redefine” Christianity as “a private and highly circumscribed matter of individual preference,”¹¹ making each believer an independent unit of religious worship, rendering religion “an individual rather than common matter [and thereby] signaling the emergence of an intensely individualistic and privatistic believer.”¹²

The postulate formalizes a claim made in the preceding paragraph of the *Letter* that “All the Life and Power of true Religion consists in the inward and full perswasion of the mind.”¹³ As no one can compel inward persuasion, individuals are free to believe as they please. This is an agreed datum in otherwise disparate and rivalrous interpretations of Locke’s case for religious toleration.¹⁴ With and after Locke, religion is a matter of belief, that is, of “voluntary or private thought;” and, because thought cannot be coerced, “Freedom of religion” triumphs.¹⁵ Meanwhile “Christianity as an institutionalized worldview” is “abandoned like the wake left behind a Dutch merchant ship in the North Sea.”¹⁶

11 Brad S. Gregory, *The Unintended Reformation: How a Religious Revolution Secularized Society* (Harvard University Press, 2012), 166.

12 Wendy Brown, *Regulating Aversion: Tolerance in the Age of Identity and Empire* (Princeton University Press, 2006), 30.

13 Locke, *A Letter*, 26.

14 See e.g. Jeremy Waldron, “Locke: Toleration and the Rationality of Persecution,” in *Justifying Toleration: Conceptual and Historical Perspectives*, ed. Susan Mendus (Cambridge University Press, 1988), 61–86, restated in *God, Locke, and Equality: Christian Foundations in Locke’s Political Thought* (Cambridge University Press, 2002), 210; Mark Goldie, “The Theory of Religious Intolerance in Restoration England,” in *From Persecution to Toleration: the Glorious Revolution and Religion in England*, ed. Ole Peter Grell, Jonathan I. Israel, and Nicholas Tyacke (Clarendon Press, 1991), 331–368; Douglas J. Casson, “The Rationality of Toleration Revisited or, Why Locke thinks we should Suffer Disagreement and Tolerate Division,” *Perspectives on Political Science* 50 (2021): 106–118; and Victor Nuovo, *John Locke; The Philosopher as Christian Virtuoso* (Oxford University Press, 2017), 205; Paul Bou-Habib, “Locke, Sincerity and the Rationality of Persecution,” *Political Studies* 51 (2003): 611–626; Richard Vernon, “Tempers and Toleration: Re-Reading Locke’s ‘Irrationality’ Argument,” *History of Political Thought* 42 (2021): 252–268, esp. 263–64.

15 Scott Robinson, *John Locke and the Uncivilized Society: Individualism and Resistance in America Today* (Lexington Books, 2021), 218; 153.

16 Gregory, *The Unintended Reformation*, 166.

The disappearance of institutionalized Christianity is similarly inevitable. If “true and saving Religion” consists in “an inward perswasion of the Mind” then churches are at best incidental or inessential to religion¹⁷ and at worst obsolescent.¹⁸ Either way they are superfluous to salvation.¹⁹ The postulate is the keystone that locks this view of Locke into place and enables it to bear its own weight.

There is a hitherto unnoticed problem with the prevalent view. The problem is that Locke did *not* think that religion consisted in an inward persuasion of the mind. Still less true and saving religion. In his view, religion was neither private nor optional because “knowledge of a God & his absolute Power over them” put “all men everywhere upon thoughts of religion” and “the necessity of uniteing into Societies about it.”²⁰ That necessity arose because religion embraced matters besides belief that were no less salient to salvation.

Principal amongst these was a requirement for worship. “*That God is to be worshipped*”, Locke declared in *An Essay concerning Human Understanding*, is “without doubt, as great a Truth as any that can enter into the mind of Man, and deserves the first place amongst all practical Principles.”²¹ This was a matter of knowledge, and so certainty, rather than subjective opinion—a truth that called for “Conformity of Action, not barely speculative assent,”²² and collective public action at that, because worship is, by Locke’s definition, a public activity.

17 John Perry, “Locke’s Accidental Church: the *Letter concerning Toleration* and the Church’s Witness to the State,” *Journal of Church and State* 47 (2005): 269–288.

18 William T. Cavanaugh, “‘A Fire Strong Enough to Consume the House’: The Wars of Religion and the Rise of the State,” *Modern Theology* 11 (1995): 397–420, at 399.

19 Diego Lucci, *John Locke’s Christianity* (Cambridge University Press, 2020), 197.

20 MS. Locke c. 34, pp. 76–77.

21 Locke, *An Essay*, I. iv. 7, 87.

22 Locke, *An Essay*, I. iii. 3, 67.

Worshippers are required to bear witness to God and His truth. Witness implies the presence of more than one human being. Accordingly, “the actions of a private solitary life cannot reach to all the instances & purposes of religion in its full extent.”²³ Some of the “great ends of religion” are “to be attained only in societies”—the societies Locke calls churches.²⁴ Salvation cannot be achieved by individualistic and privatistic believers in splendid isolation.²⁵ Why, then, did Locke contradict himself by declaring that true and saving religion consisted in the inward persuasion of the mind?

The answer is as simple as it is startling: he did not. But this is merely to state an answer, not to develop it. The next section of this article clears the ground for that development.

I. CLEARING THE GROUND

Late in life Locke remarked that “one should not dispute with a man who either through stupidity or shamelessness denies plain and visible truths.”²⁶ To suggest that he never claimed that true and saving religion consisted in an inward persuasion of the mind may provoke the same response, for apparently obvious reasons: it is susceptible to immediate and seemingly incontrovertible refutation by opening a copy of the *Letter* at the relevant page and pointing. The printed word gives the lie direct. To insist on the opposite in the face of this inconvenient fact invites not only derision but considerable scholarly indignation, for the suggestion contradicts both common sense and 350 years of Locke studies. Nevertheless, the suggestion is true, and in more than one sense.

23 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 19.

24 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 23.

25 Brown, *Regulating Aversion*, 30.

26 John Locke, “Disputatio,” [1700], *Adversaria* 1661, p. 22, Bodleian MS. Film 77.

It is trivially true because, as no-one denies—though few remark—the postulate was not a product of Locke’s pen. It was the work of his first translator, William Popple, who turned Locke’s *Epistola de Tolerantia* into the English text most readers encounter as the *Letter*.²⁷ Popple, a unitarian, was the author of several tracts on rational religion.²⁸ He regarded “the Laws and Rules of true Christianity” as “in substance, the very same with the Laws of Nature.”²⁹ He supposed that all God required for people to be saved was “*an upright Heart, a pure Mind, and a clear Conscience*.”³⁰ To “live in innocence” was sufficient worship. True religion consisted “*neither in Ceremonys nor Notions, but in Sincerity and Practice*,” viz, the love of God and of one’s neighbor.³¹ Each and every individual was obliged to use their own reason and judgment in matters of religion.³² Anything that frustrated or obstructed their free exercise was *eo ipso* illegitimate. Thus “*Liberty of Conscience... Universal, Impartial, and Inviolable*” was the “*great Duty, both of Governors and People*.”³³

Popple, then, wanted “*Absolute liberty*” and he took some with Locke’s text, adding a preface on his own account without identifying it as such and departing from Locke’s Latin in

27 John Locke, *Epistola de Tolerantia / A Letter on Toleration*, translated by J. W. Gough, ed. R. Klibansky (Clarendon Press, 1968). I have made my own translations from the Latin text throughout.

28 For Popple’s life, career, and thought, see Caroline Robbins, “Absolute Liberty: The Life and Thought of William Popple, 1638–1708,” *The William and Mary Quarterly* 24 (1967): 190–223. For some of his other dealings with Locke, see Mark Goldie, “John Locke, the Early Lockeans, and Priestcraft,” *Intellectual History Review* 28 (2018): 125–144.

29 William Popple, *A Discourse of Humane Reason with Relation to Matters of Religion* (London, 1690), 71.

30 Popple, *A Discourse*, 64. Compare William Popple, *A Rational Catechism* (London, 1687), 71, which identifies God’s requisites as “Spiritual Adoration”, “Purity and Integrity of Heart”, “Unblameableness of Life and Conversation”, and “A Conscience void of Offence both towards God and towards Men.”

31 Popple, *A Rational Catechism*, 127. These prepossessions go some way to explaining why Popple might have chosen to translate Locke’s words as he did. Locke was apparently aware that Popple was at work on a translation in early summer 1689 but told a trusted correspondent only that he understood that “some Englishman” had taken it up. See Locke to Philippus van Limborch, 6 June 1689, no. 1147, in Locke, *Correspondence*, 3: 633–4. When he finally admitted his authorship of the *Epistola*, in the codicil he added to his will in 1704, he stated that the translation was done “without my privacy” i.e., without direct communication between the two about its contents. See “Locke: Will”, in Locke, *Correspondence*, 8:426 .

32 Popple, *A Discourse*, 10–11.

33 Popple, *A Discourse*, 96.

numerous places.³⁴ Modern scholars, notably Gough, have observed Popple’s “tendency to inflate and exaggerate.”³⁵ Gough emphasized that “Popple’s was not a literal translation,” adding that “there would be no point” listing all the places “where it departs from the actual wording of the Latin.”³⁶ His own translation of Locke’s Latin text recorded Popple’s “more seriously inaccurate” errors,³⁷ but, when it came to the postulate, Gough followed directly in Popple’s footsteps.

The postulate is Popple’s translation of Locke’s “cum autem vera et salutifera religio consistit in interna anima fide.”³⁸ Gough repeated Popple’s translation verbatim,³⁹ as did Montuori,⁴⁰ merely modernizing his spelling: “But true and saving religion consists in the inward persuasion of the mind.” Silverthorne prefers “conviction” to “persuasion”⁴¹ Fontanelle Loque “faith”;⁴² but all agree that this inward something—whether persuasion, conviction, or faith—is the thing in and of which Locke understands true and saving religion to consist.

Another “something” has been ignored—namely, whether Locke could possibly have meant that their “something” was the thing in and of which true and saving religion *consisted*. “Consistit” is the third person singular present of “consisto,” which has more than one meaning. Of these “consist of” is certainly one, and it can, as here, take an ablative. But others are “to be based or dependent on”, “to stand with”, or “to be valid”, which also take ablatives. Which is correct?

34 See Locke, *A Letter*, “To the Reader” [by Popple], 21: “*Absolute Liberty, Just and True Liberty, Equal and Impartial Liberty, is the thing that we stand in need of.*”

35 Locke, *Epistola*, 51.

36 Locke, *Epistola*, 50.

37 Locke, *Epistola*, 156–63.

38 Locke, *Epistola*, 68.

39 Locke, *Epistola*, 69.

40 John Locke, *A Letter concerning Toleration*, ed. Mario Montuori (Springer, 1963), 19.

41 *Locke on Toleration*, ed. Richard Vernon, with translations by Michael Silverthorne (Cambridge University Press, 2010), 8.

42 Flavio Fontenelle Loque, *John Locke and the Grounds for Toleration* (Springer, 2022), 41.

We shall see presently that in works written both before and after the *Letter*, Locke stated explicitly that outward worship was necessary to salvation; but the more immediate point is that the whole rationale of discussing free worship in *that* text is obviated if he meant “consist of”. If salvation involves *only* inward persuasion, “tolerantia” is otiose. There is no need to argue for toleration of and between different Christian groups⁴³ if groups are surplus to requirements. It follows that it must be “depends on” or “requires.” Locke was not claiming that true and saving religion *consisted in* inward persuasion but rather that it required it. He was identifying a necessary but insufficient condition of true and saving religion.

Just a paragraph before the postulate, Locke contrasts outward worship with thought: when worship is conducted without genuine faith in its efficacy, he says, it is useless. Salvation cannot depend on *actions* alone, because “in fide autem consistit vero ac salutiferae religionis vis et efficacia.”⁴⁴ He can scarcely have jumped from salvation depends on faith *and* worship, to salvation requires *only* faith in the next paragraph,⁴⁵ then back to both action *and* belief subsequently.⁴⁶ It is the combination of faith and works that makes an *Epistola de Tolerantia* necessary—different societies of Christians inevitably disagree about the ways of worship acceptable to God, and [Locke says] “these religious societies I call churches, and these the magistrate must tolerate”, even if, in practice, all too often he did not.⁴⁷ Churches differed in their forms of worship *and* their doctrines, which needed “to be handled separately” if the

43 See Locke, *Epistola*, 80–85, 103–121.

44 Locke, *Epistola*, 66.

45 Locke, *Epistola*, 68.

46 Locke, *Epistola*, 98:

47 Locke, *Epistola*, 100: “Has societates religiosas ecclesias voco, quas magistratus tolerare debet.” The requirement for faith and good works, as opposed to faith alone, is emphasized in e.g. James 2: 14–26.

question of toleration was to be understood correctly, indicating again that faith and worship were equally pertinent.⁴⁸

Supplementary evidence is supplied by the fact that, partly to brush up his Latin before writing the *Epistola*, Locke made a renewed study of Cicero's works.⁴⁹ There he would have discovered multiple instances of the same usage of "consistit." In *Pro Publio Quinctio*, for example, Cicero says of the kind of evidence that makes for an open and shut case, "Nimirum...in eo causa consistit," "the whole cause undoubtedly turns upon it."⁵⁰ In *De Inventione* he writes that "Ratio est autem, cum omnis quaestio non in scriptione, sed in aliqua argumentatione consistit," "there is a case of general reasoning... when the whole question turns, not on a written document, but on some logical proof."⁵¹ In *De Lege Agraria*, he addresses the Roman people as "vos, quorum gratia in suffragiis consistit," "You, whose influence depends on your votes."⁵² In *De Finibus*, it is said that "Omnis auctoritas philosophiae... consistit in beata vita comparanda."⁵³ No one could conceivably think that the *auctoritas* of anything is *equivalent* to conceptions of "the good life". Cicero's usage thus fits with "depends upon" or "turns upon," rather than "consists in," providing suggestive parallels to Locke's usage.

This finding invites us to investigate Locke's other uses of the verb, including his claim in *Two Tracts* (1660–62) that divine worship is best understood in the first place as internal acts

48 Locke, *Epistola*, 100–102: "de utrisque separatim agendum est."

49 Kiyoshi Shimokawa, "Locke's Concept of Justice," in *The Philosophy of John Locke: New Perspectives*, ed. Peter Anstey (Routledge, 2003), 61–85, at 72.

50 Cicero, *Pro Publio Quinctio*, 25.79, in *Pro Quinctio. Pro Roscio Amerino. Pro Roscio Comoedo. On the Agrarian Law*, translated by J. H. Freese (Harvard University Press, 1930), 86.

51 Cicero, *De Inventione*, 1.13, in *On Invention. The Best Kind of Orator. Topics*, translated by H. M. Hubbell (Harvard University Press, 1949), 36.

52 Cicero, *De Lege Agraria*, 2.37.102, in *Pro Quinctio [and] On the Agrarian Law*, 480.

53 Cicero, *De Finibus Bonorum et Malorum*, 5.29.86, in *On Ends*, translated by Harris Rackham (Harvard University Press, 1914), 488.

of veneration with God as their object, and “Hic est internus ille animi cultus quem poscit deus, in quo vis et anima religionis consistit.”⁵⁴ Abrams translates this passage, with its evocative echoes of the postulate, as “this is that inner worship of the heart which God demands, in which the essence and soul of religion consists,”⁵⁵ even though, in the next paragraph, Locke adds that the outward acts of religion are *also* called divine worship, something God requires of people everywhere as a means of rousing the “rest of mankind...to the worship and reverence of his divine majesty” and of bearing witness to His truth and our love of Him.⁵⁶ It better fits both Locke’s usage and his argument to translate him as saying then what he said to the end of his days, namely that “the essence and soul of religion” *depended or turned upon* “the inner worship of the heart.”

This is what he was saying in the *Letter* too: without the “inward judgment” that the chosen mode of outward worship was the true one, and without the love of God that worship was intended to express, salvation was impossible: “whatever you offer in outward worship, if you are not fully persuaded in your own heart that it is both true and well pleasing to God,... it is an obstacle to salvation.”⁵⁷ But freely offered outward worship is the fitting bodily expression of full persuasion of the mind. Neither is sufficient independently of the other. Certainly it is not sufficient to say (as Philip Milton has said) that with Locke “individual believers can, and usually will, join together to form churches...or other religious societies.”⁵⁸; they are *required* to do so.

54 John Locke, *Two Tracts on Government*, ed. Philip Abrams (Cambridge University Press, 1967), 188.

55 Locke, *Two Tracts*, 214.

56 Locke, *Two Tracts*, 214–15.

57 Locke, *Epistola*, 67–69: “quicquid in cultu externo praestes, si hoc et verum esse et Deo placere tibi intus in corde penitus persuasum non sit, non modo non potest ad salute, verum e contrario obest”.

58 Philip Milton, “A Letter concerning Toleration and Other Writings,” *The Scriblerian and the Kit-Cats* 44/45 (2012): 115–117, at 115.

This assertion may look flatly incompatible with Locke's insistence in the *Letter* that a church is a "*free and voluntary society*," no different from "a society of men of letters for philosophy, of merchants for commerce, or of men of leisure for mutual conversation."⁵⁹

Locke's can be deceiving. These examples are habitually read as elucidative of Locke's definition of a church and so as evidence of what Teresa M. Bejan interprets as his unstated ambition to replace "the traditional Christian, corporate understanding of membership as concord in and with the body of Christ" with "one of voluntary membership in a club or business corporation."⁶⁰ This supposition suits the prevalent view of Locke admirably well, but not his stated purpose in the paragraph of the *Letter* from which the relevant passage is drawn, which is not to elucidate what churches *are*—something he had just done—but instead, to what *laws they are subject*.⁶¹

Locke had already stipulated that a church was "*societas libera hominum sponte sua coeuntium, ut Deum publice colant eo modo quem credunt numini acceptum fore ad salutem animarum,*" a free society of people uniting of their own accord so that they may worship God publicly in the way they believe will be acceptable to the divine presence for the welfare of their souls.⁶² This having been established, "[t]he next thing", Locke tells us, is to enquire what its power is and to what laws it is subject—"Sequitur jam ut inquiramus quae sit ejus potestas, quibusque legibus subjecta."⁶³ It is in the course of this second enquiry that churches are likened to other voluntary societies which require rules prescribing conditions of admission and expulsion and regulating the conduct of their members.⁶⁴ This is not an

⁵⁹ Locke, *Epistola*, 71–73.

⁶⁰ Teresa M. Bejan, *Mere Civility: Toleration and the Limits of Disagreement* (Harvard University Press, 2017), 129.

⁶¹ Locke, *Epistola*, 70–3.

⁶² Locke, *Epistola*, 70.

⁶³ Locke, *Epistola*, 72.

⁶⁴ For Locke's understanding of such societies, compare "Rules of a Society", originally printed in *A Collection of Several Pieces of Mr. John Locke*, ed. Pierre des Maizeaux (London, 1720), 358–62, and MS. Locke c. 25, fos. 56–57, "The Rules of the Dry Club" (1692), printed and discussed in Luisa Simonutti, "Circles of *Virtuosi*

extension or elaboration of the earlier stipulative definition. It is the application of Locke's view of what a church is to a different question: namely, who has the right to legislate for and superintend those within its domain?

Locke's point is that churches, like these other associations, operate outside civil jurisdiction. They exist spatially within the commonwealth, but as self-governing collectivities whose members are bound together by laws to which they alone have assented. Membership is freely chosen. It cannot be coerced or compelled by civil power. That is a very different thing from supposing with the prevalent view that Locke saw everything from the perspective of the state and refused to regard churches as anything more than contingent consequences of voluntary private activity, akin (Bejan says) to hobby clubs, colloquiums, or commercial enterprises. Such groups—unlike “true churches”—do not, as a rule, have Christ “in their midst”.⁶⁵ (Perhaps we just move in different circles). Either way the contrast puts the apparent comparison in a somewhat clearer light.

In this light, a church is *unlike* every other voluntary association in one vital respect. It is distinguished by the union with God it instantiates and the unique importance of its end, in comparison to which all others recede into relative insignificance. The existing scholarship rightly emphasizes that Lockean churches are voluntary societies.⁶⁶ What it overlooks is

and ‘Charity under Different Opinions’: The Crucible of Locke's Last Writings,” in *Studies on Locke: Sources, Contemporaries, and Legacy*, ed. Sarah Hutton and Paul Schuurman (Springer, 2008), 159–75, at 173–75. Both sets of rules have now been printed together in John Locke, *Literary and Historical Writings*, ed. J. R. Milton (Clarendon Press, 2019), at 313–17. The “Rules for a Society” seem to relate to a colloquium Locke established while in exile in Holland in 1687, facilitated by Jean Le Clerc, and those of the “Dry Club” to a successor society that convened in London from the summer of 1692. Interestingly, Popple was its secretary. As such he was responsible for writing down its rules, which included the rule that “no Man ought, any way, to be harmed or prejudiced, in his name, Goods, or Person, for any Speculative Opinion in Religion, or Outward Way of Worship”. See Locke, *Literary and Historical Writings*, 317, and compare Robbins, “Absolute Liberty,” 208. 65 Locke, *Epistola*, 74–75.

66 Compare Bejan, *Mere Civility*, 129; Jennifer A. Herdt, “Locke, Martyrdom, and the Disciplinary Power of the Church,” *Journal of the Society of Christian Ethics* 23 (2003): 19–35; Perry, “Locke's Accidental Church,” esp. 274 and 286; Richard H. Popkin and Mark Goldie “Scepticism, Priestcraft, and Toleration,” in *The*

Locke's insistence that they are also supernatural societies "wherein man associates himself to god angels & holy men" and that "part of the bond of their association is a law revealed concerning what worship god would have donne unto him" to win salvation.⁶⁷ Salvation is impossible without church membership, which is integral to the worship God requires—but also, we shall see, integral to the fulsome faith He rewards. The next section of the article explains why.

II. NATURAL THEOLOGY, NATURAL RELIGION, AND CHRISTIANITY

Explanation begins with the crucial foundation supplied by Locke's natural theology. Locke supposed that the proper function of mankind was what "nature has prepared him to perform." Their natural faculties, which included sense and reason, led human beings to certain knowledge of God as their maker and sustainer.⁶⁸ The terms of that relationship were such that what He provided could not be returned by them. The appropriate response was therefore gratitude, which found expression in worship.⁶⁹

Worship worthy of Him would give Him thanks in accordance with His will through the exercise of the gifts He had bestowed. It would involve actions of the body and the soul together, offering Him the obeisance of the first and the love of the second: "outward performance" animated by the "sentiments of respect and love for the deity" to which "we are

Cambridge History of Eighteenth-Century Political Thought, ed. Mark Goldie and Robert Wokler (Cambridge University Press, 2006), 79–109, at 105; Manfred Svensson, "Locke, Toleration, and the Church", *Jahrbuch für Religionsphilosophie* 15 (2016): 47–66; Ward, *John Locke and Modern Life*, 231.

⁶⁷ Bodleian Library, MS. Locke d. 10, p. 43 ("Ecclesia," [1682]). Printed in Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 391–92.

⁶⁸ John Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, ed. Wolfgang von Leyden (Clarendon Press, 1954), no. 4, 153–57.

⁶⁹ Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, no. 7, 195–99.

obliged for ever.”⁷⁰ And it would be witnessed by others because one purpose of worship was to render praise and express gratitude before the world.

In worship we make our obedience manifest not only to God but to all. It is only by acting in concert via the public submission of ourselves, body and soul, to Him that we may attain His ends. We cannot know, by reason alone, whether the particular actions we undertake are the right ones to please Him, but we do know (because Locke tells us as much) that obedience to natural law through the visible performance of our duties to Him is the way to glorify Him.⁷¹

In this way God’s action and worship form the basis of natural religion, which calls for external actions, arising out of the relation of dependence in which people stand to Him, by which they confess themselves His servants. In short, reason identifies a necessity for every individual to join with others to glorify God and express thanks to Him, outwardly and collectively, for the benefits they continue to receive and cannot requite in kind.

This is not only a matter of natural duty. It is also a Christian duty—for when “The Christian Religion...came into the world,” Locke argued, it “proceeded upon the same grounds [as natural religion],” laying on its followers “the same necessity of public worship on the same account.”⁷² So there is a duty of church membership, incumbent on each and every individual, Christian *and* non-Christian, which serves the end of salvation, and is in principle known to all.

Salvation is the highest end and first care of all human beings,⁷³ above bodily self-preservation, material prosperity, or public peace, the soul being “of more worth than all the

⁷⁰ Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, no. 7, 193–95.

⁷¹ Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, no. 4, 156.

⁷² MS. Locke c. 34, p. 77.

⁷³ Locke, *Epistola*, 131: “Prima animae cura habenda.”

World.”⁷⁴ The duty to worship publicly to that end was complemented by a charitable care for the souls of others that required people to encourage a love of religion and truth in their fellows and to bring them to the way of worship they judged true. Revelation affirmed what reason surmised—that religion included not only belief and sentiment but a structure of public action. As Locke put it in 1699, true religion was “Beleiveing & Doeing those things w^{ch} [we conceive] will render us acceptable” to “the one only true god.” And that “consists in these three parts

1° The Beleif of such Truths as he has proposed & requires everyone to

Beleive

2° In worshiping him in a way acceptable to him

3° In obeying his commands,”

thereby confirming worship’s “first place” among practical principles.⁷⁵

The duty to worship publicly figured in Locke’s writings from the very beginning. The second of his “Two Tracts on Government” (c.1662) observed that “since God ordained that man should be composed of body as well as soul,” he required “the obedience of both,” and since “He seeks due service and recognition for himself on earth he is not satisfied with that silent and almost furtive form of worship alone, but he has required his worshippers... to acknowledge his name openly”. Indeed “he demands those outward performances by which the inner worship of the spirit is expressed”, by which we “bear witness here and now to the love, faith, and obedience of the soul, or else strengthen it for the future; and this is the

⁷⁴ John Locke, *The Reasonableness of Christianity, as Delivered in the Scriptures*, ed. John C. Higgins-Biddle (Clarendon Press, 1999), 124.

⁷⁵ John Locke, “Religio,” [1699], *Adversaria* 1661, p. 20, Bodleian MS. Film 77.

worship called external which is everywhere ordained by God in his law, and which... we are bound to fulfil, nor does the magistrate possess any right over this worship since it can be altered by none but the divine Lawgiver himself.”⁷⁶ This “true worship” could be fulfilled only “in public gatherings and outward actions.”⁷⁷

Locke stayed true to this course. He changed his mind about many matters as circumstances changed about him and continued to refine and sometimes revise his own thinking throughout his life; but he never resiled from the assumption that there was a duty to worship publicly in corporate groups. In 1664 he called the “outward worship of the Deity” a universal duty.⁷⁸ In 1667, he stated that “Divine worship” belonged with “speculative opinions”—opinions which “would be still the same with all the consequences of them though there were noe other person besides [their possessor] in the world”—as having “an absolute and universall right to toleration.”⁷⁹ If it belonged *with* speculative opinions, it could not *be* opinion. Rather, it was action, or more precisely, and as Locke’s examples indicate, collective public action, with its own “place, time, and manner” of expression:⁸⁰

if I observe the friday with the Mahumetan, or the Saturday with the Jew, or the sunday with the Christian, whether... I worship God in the various & pompous ceremonies of the papists, or in the plainer way of the Calvinists. I see noe thing in any of these, if they be donne sincerely & out of conscience, that can of it self make me, either the worse subject to my prince, or worse neighbour to my fellow subject.⁸¹

⁷⁶ Locke, *Two Tracts*, 214–15.

⁷⁷ Locke, *Two Tracts*, 216.

⁷⁸ Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, no. 6, 195; 199.

⁷⁹ Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 272.

⁸⁰ Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 272.

⁸¹ Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 274.

This was because acts of worship related only to God and so had no bearing upon government, which was concerned only with practical matters; that is to say, those which involved the mutual conduct of citizens.⁸²

Article XCV of *The Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina*, which Locke helped to draft in 1669,⁸³ required all freemen of Carolina to “acknowledge a GOD” and declared “that God is publicly and solemnly to be worshipped.”⁸⁴ Article XCVII granted toleration to “heathens, Jews, and other dissenters from the purity of Christian religion” with the avowed aim of encouraging their Christian conversion, stipulating that “any seven or more persons, agreeing in any religion, shall constitute a church or profession, to which they shall give some name to distinguish it from others,”⁸⁵ “church” being the generic name Locke gave to any and every religious society, each of which was formed, *inter alia*, for the purpose of performing the natural duty to worship.⁸⁶

The members of every church were required to “bear witness to truth” and “in their terms of communion set down the external way whereby they witness a truth as in the presence of God.”⁸⁷ That is why “seven or more persons” were needed to form a church: because, from Roman Law, a valid testament could only be made orally before seven witnesses.⁸⁸ Every church originated in the fact that its members interpreted the demands of a natural duty to

82 Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 271–89. The point being that it was not the speculative beliefs or modes of worship of Roman Catholic subjects that made them intolerable, but rather the practical belief that they owed their allegiance to a foreign prince, the Pope, who claimed a power above and beyond that of the commonwealth.

83 See J. R. Milton, “John Locke and the Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina,” *Locke Newsletter* 21 (1990):111–133 and compare Jack Turner, “John Locke, Christian Mission, and Colonial America,” *Modern Intellectual History* 8 (2011): 267–297.

84 *The Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina* [1669], in John Locke, *Works* (10 vols., Thomas Tegg, 1823), 10:175–199, at 193.

85 Locke, *Works*, x, 193–94.

86 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 78.

87 Locke, *Works*, x, 195.

88 *The Institutes of Justinian*, ed. Thomas Collett Sandars (Longmans, Green, & Co., 1865), II.xx.14, 254.

require *this* manner of worship. It was defined not in terms of the truth or validity of that interpretation but rather of the will and agreement to unite to give it practical expression.⁸⁹ Everyone had to belong to some church; and “slaves, as well as others” were free to “be of what church any of them shall think best.”⁹⁰

Locke laid out his reasoning in a 1676 journal entry: “God, being the Lord and maker both of the body and the soul, requires the homage and worship of both the body and the soul. That inward one of the mind is principally acceptable to Him, whereby we acknowledge His power and sovereignty and our dependence and thankfulness and...dispose our minds to faith and obedience”. But “He requires also the homage of our bodies, both to testify that inward one to men and by our example to draw them to the worship of Him likewise.”⁹¹ The same requirement appeared in the *Epistola*: “all men know and acknowledge that God ought to be worshipped publicly”—*Quorsum alias ad coetum publicos cogimur?* “why else are they bound to convene in public groups?”⁹² Popple rendered this as “Why otherwise do they compel one another unto the publick assemblies?,”⁹³ capturing thereby not only the requirement for witness and so the group character of worship but also the impulse to persuade others to join us.

The duty to perform public acts of worship was reiterated in Locke’s final masterpiece, *A Paraphrase and Notes on the Epistles of St. Paul*. Locke construed Romans 12: 1–2 to be saying that after Christ’s coming, the way to salvation for Jews and Gentiles alike was by faith in Jesus Christ, purity and holiness of life, and offering to God through the use of their

89 MS. Locke c. 34, pp. 2–3.

90 Locke, *Works*, x, 195. Turner, “John Locke, Christian Mission, and Colonial America,” 276–78, identifies Locke as the principal author of the relevant article (CVII).

91 Bodleian Library, MS. Locke f. 1, p. 321, printed in Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, 261.

92 Locke, *Epistola*, 100.

93 Locke, *A Letter*, 38.

hearts, minds, *and* bodies “such a way of worship as becomes a rational creature,” that is, worship in the sight of others.⁹⁴ Sometimes Locke derived this duty to worship from Christian revelation;⁹⁵ sometimes from reason,⁹⁶ sometimes both together,⁹⁷ but the fluidity of the demarcation between the two modes of promulgation was only additional proof of the identity of the general providential scheme they disclosed between them.

On this view Christianity is a *resumé* of the knowledge of God already attained and a disclosure of further truths which could not have been thought out by reason but which, once divinely communicated, approve themselves to the same reason that discovers a God who created and governs the world with wisdom, equity, and beneficence and is owed thanks in the form of worship in return.⁹⁸ Locke’s position thus went beyond Popple’s: Popple assumed that natural theology and natural religion were in principle sufficient to salvation whereas Locke regarded them as a necessary but insufficient propaedeutic to Christian truth.

This was so because although, in Locke’s judgment, natural theology agreed with revelation, it was not co-extensive with it. Revelation stated some matters which reason did not disclose⁹⁹ and elucidated others which established beyond reasonable doubt that Christianity was the one true religion which alone saved. Locke understood it as a fact of the matter that this was so: “The Evidence of our Saviour’s *Mission* from Heaven is so great, in the multitude of Miracles he did before all sorts of People; that what he delivered cannot but be

94 John Locke, *A Paraphrase and Notes on the Epistles of St. Paul*, ed. Arthur W. Wainwright (2 vols., Clarendon Press, 1987), 2:581–84.

95 See e.g. Locke, *Two Tracts*, 187–91/213–18.

96 Compare Locke, *Essays on the Law of Nature*, no. 7, 194; Locke, *Epistola*, 100; Locke, *An Essay*, I. iv. 7, 87 and I. iv. 19, 96.

97 MS. Locke c. 34, 77.

98 See Mark Pattison, “Tendencies of Religious Thought in England, 1688–1750,” in *Essays*, ed. Henry Nettleship (2 vols., Clarendon Press, 1889), 2:42–118, at 45–64.

99 For one such, see note 105, below.

received as the Oracles of God, and unquestionable Verity.”¹⁰⁰ Yet he continued to insist that there were some “great ends of religion to be attained only in societies”¹⁰¹ which were “subservient to this main end viz.... salvation.”¹⁰²

These ends were “edification,” “the publick worship of God,” and “the propagation of truth.”¹⁰³ In Locke’s words, “Christian Religion made it the duty of its followers, to unite into societies for publick worship, profession, & propagation of its doctrines, & edification of one another.”¹⁰⁴ If churches *per se* were corporate groups composed of seven or more members, Christian churches were constituted by fewer than half that number, for Christ had revealed that he would be in their midst wherever “*two or three are gathered together in [his] name.*”¹⁰⁵

Two or three sufficed to satisfy the requirement for witness because, as Christ reminded the Pharisees, it was “written in your law, that the testimony of two men is true. I am one that bear witness of myself, and the Father that sent me beareth witness of me.”¹⁰⁶ Uniting into a church, then, was “for the propagation of truth as well as the worship of god.”¹⁰⁷ What, though, of the third great end of religion, edification?

III. EDIFICATION, GRACE, AND FULL PERSUASION

Locke defined edification as “right informing of the understanding & subduing of the

100 See Locke, *Reasonableness*, 142–43.

101 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 23.

102 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 3.

103 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 23.

104 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 77.

105 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 105, citing Matt 18: 20. Compare Locke, *Epistola*, 72–74.

106 John 8: 17–18, alluding to Deut. 19: 15.

107 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 30. Compare Matt. 28: 17–20.

will.”¹⁰⁸ He used this conception to connect the various constituents in terms of which people were equipped to do as duty demanded and think and act rightly. Understanding and will are obviously central to the ways people think and act; and because these powers belong to individuals, it is easy to mistake Locke’s conception as one more expression of his “radical individualist principles.”¹⁰⁹ In fact, it presupposes the structure provided by a corporate group and the mutual love and support it sustains.

The edification of the individual and that of the collectivity are one and the same process with Locke. As Christians grow in the strength of their faith, they communicate that strength to other members of the same church and are edified by them in their turn. In Locke’s words, “The union they have as members in the same body makes them all equally share in one another’s good and evil; gives them a mutual esteem and concerne one for another, and leaves no room for contests or divisions amongst them about their gifts, or the honour and place due to them upon that account.”¹¹⁰ Artificial distinctions of rank are abolished. As church members they associate not as freemen and slaves but as equal subjects of “Christ’s Kingdome” united with him and each other in “obedience to his Laws, & Love to one another.”¹¹¹

An effect is to yoke the natural desire for esteem to moral injunctions commanding virtuous behaviour rather than to status, keeping religion and its practitioners in good countenance and reputation and fostering “exemplariness of life in conversation”—meaning social interaction and intercourse.¹¹² In true churches, everything necessary to be known, believed, and

108 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 23.

109 Ward, *John Locke and Modern Life*, 235.

110 Locke, *Paraphrase*, 2:229.

111 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 148.

112 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 25 and compare p. 110.

performed in order to salvation is taught and repeated, inculcating habits of humility, sobriety and charity as their members pursue salvation in conscious communion with others for whose souls they are exhibiting a charitable care in worshipping with them.¹¹³

God's stated wish to be "Worshipped in Spirit and in Truth; with Application of Mind, and sincerity of Heart", which is often taken as evidence that He no longer cared to be worshipped in public in corporate groups,¹¹⁴ simply reflected Christ's revelation that the "Magnificent Temples" of Judaism and the "splendor and distinction of Habits, and pomp of Ceremonies, and all [its] outside Performances, might now be spared," having been superseded by his coming. Henceforth the needs of "Edification," rather than the requirements of Mosaic Law, would "regulate all... publick Acts of Worship,"¹¹⁵ which remained integral to true and saving religion.¹¹⁶

To join with others in collective worship demands diligent use of the natural faculties given by God: glorifying Him, edifying the heart and the mind and deepening faith through hearing the Gospel preached. The latter, Locke maintains, is the only means "our Saviour hath appointed to make true converts" by "the informeing & converting the mind."¹¹⁷ As he would later avow—reciting St. Paul—"Faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God."¹¹⁸ But Locke insisted that it did not come in the ordinary way of audition, intellectual perception, and assent to propositions. Something more was involved—something extraordinary in source and effects.

113 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 48.

114 Lucci, *John Locke's Christianity*, 196–97.

115 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 159–60.

116 See e.g. Matt. 10: 32.

117 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 48.

118 John Locke, *A Second Letter concerning Toleration* (London, 1690), 19, quoting Rom. 10: 17.

The something more was grace. The Gospel not only contained “all that [God] would have done for the salvation of souls” in terms suitable to even the lowest capacities of rational creatures but also, inscrutably, “all the means of grace” needed to enlighten even the highest.¹¹⁹ Only with this supernatural assistance, delivered via the Spirit of God, was mankind raised to a new potential and brought to a full persuasion of the truths of Christianity.

This was true even of Christ’s first disciples, to whom he promised the gracious assistance of “the Holy Ghost.” “*When the Paraclet is come, the Spirit of Truth, he shall witness concerning me... he will guide you into all Truth; and he will shew you things to come: He shall glorifie me.* By the Spirit, when he comes, ye shall be fully instructed concerning me.”¹²⁰ It may be worth adding that this indicates a rather broader understanding of the ineffectiveness of persecution by the state in changing belief than the one attributed to Locke in sundry works of commentary. As he himself reflected,

I cannot but marvel at the unwarranted arrogance of those who think that they can deliver the things necessary to salvation more clearly and perspicuously than the Holy Spirit.¹²¹

Christ made good upon this promise to his disciples and sent his Spirit among them after his Passion and Resurrection, when they were united as a church, “all with one accord in one place.”¹²² Until that time they could “be *perswaded of* no more than was proposed to them;

119 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 159, 163.

120 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 101, paraphrasing John 15: 26 and 16: 13.

121 Locke, *Epistola*, 154: “Non possum non mirari inauspicatam illorum arrogantiam, qui ea quae ad salutem sunt necessaria putant se clarius et dilucidius posse tradere, quam Spiritus Sanctus... tradere possit.”

122 Acts 2: 1.

Embrace no more than was revealed; according to the Promises they had received, and the Dispensations they were under.”¹²³ Only afterwards, with the new dispensation of grace from the Holy Spirit, did they have “full... perswasion” that Christ was the Messiah and the meaning of his kingdom was fully revealed and understood aright by them: Now they had “a full and clear sight” of what was necessary to salvation.¹²⁴

This clarification reaffirmed the need to do good works;¹²⁵ but such works as were accompanied by that inward and full persuasion of the mind that his Spirit made possible. What was true of the disciples then applied thenceforth to all mankind: “If we do what we can [Christ] will give us his Spirit to help us do what, and how we should”.¹²⁶

The “what” is believing and doing such things as will render us acceptable to the one true God. The “how” is out of love for Him. The requisites of salvation, then, are an understanding rightly informed, a will to follow God’s will, and a loving disposition. All three are fruits of edification, the “right informing of the understanding & subdueing of the will,” which involves the supplementation of natural means by the Spirit of God and his gift of grace. Edification is inextricably bound up with church membership, being one of its ends. It is so not least, we can now add, because God’s grace moves only within certain channels and churches are the vessels of that grace.

This grace was available to anyone who offered Him the worship they judged to be most

123 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 138.

124 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 101. I owe this point to Joshua Mitchell, “John Locke and the Theological Foundation of Liberal Toleration: A Christian Dialectic of History,” *The Review of Politics* 52 (1990): 64–83. Cf. MS. Locke c. 34, 127, which describes the Apostles as thenceforth endowed with “infallible spirit” through the church.

125 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 108–20, 130.

126 Locke, *Reasonableness*, 163. This position was hiding in plain sight in the first edition of *An Essay*. See note 1 above.

pleasing to Him, in whichever church “reason, & Christian Charity shall dictate to be most convenient”¹²⁷ and “most conduceable to those ends for which I am of any.”¹²⁸ This studied lack of institutional specificity did not make church membership optional. It made choice obligatory. In Locke’s words, “though I allow the Gospell to be divine & of highest obligation yet [it] can direct me no farther then what I understand it to speak, & therefore though I resolve & think myself obliged to be a Christian, yet that takes not away my liberty of joyneing with the assembly... of Christians” I judge “readiest safest & most effectual in [the] great end Salvation.”¹²⁹ The prevalent view has things exactly backwards: in emphasising, with Acts, that a church was “a free society of men, joining together with one accord”,¹³⁰ Locke was not *denying* that Christ founded a church by his divine authority.¹³¹ He was making an analytic inference from the manner of its founding:

God in the Scripture not obligeing me to be of any particular Church that I doe not find constituted there, nor the establishment of any particular Church obligeing me any longer then I am of it, I cannot but be at liberty to chuse.¹³²

Yet the exercise of that liberty was a duty, not an option—and a duty that led mankind to grace and that needed to be done if grace were to be received rightly. At a moment when some of Locke’s associates and most ardent admirers had begun to agitate to move beyond church membership,¹³³ it remained to his mind, for all the reasons given, indispensable.

127 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 22.

128 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 36.

129 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 22, p. 146.

130 Locke, *Epistola*, 70.

131 Pace Ward, *John Locke and Modern Life*, 231.

132 MS. Locke c. 34, p. 22.

133 See Goldie, “Locke, the Early Lockians, and Priestcraft,” 126–30, which identifies Benjamin Furly as the “most persistent and raucously anti-clerical voice” in Locke’s immediate circle. Furly was “a Quaker in the process of renouncing Quakerism”, apparently for its excessively hierocratic tendencies. In unpublished writings, Popple commended the Quakers for their sincerity and priestlessness and expressed sympathy for the etiolated model of religious society on which they had resolved: “They feel each other’s Witness. And We see /

What unites the members of every church is the judgment that salvation is only possible for them within it. It is sacramental in that its meaning and authority derives from what is behind and within it—divine grace and the promise of salvation. Its members are bound together by their agreement about what certain supernatural claims require of them. Hence Locke’s observation, ventriloquizing Hooker, that a church is a “supernatural societie” as well as “a societie by consent,”¹³⁴ one that holds together different seekers after salvation for as long as they judge that this is where what is sought will be found and seek to draw others to the way of worship they think true.

Locke seems to have identified a kindred position in Jean Claude’s *La Défense de la Réformation* (1673), which he recorded in his commonplace book in 1679 under the heading “Ecclesia visibilis”:

The visibility of a true Church as we regard it is not to be able to say distinctly and with certainty, “Behold, these are the true followers of Jesus Christ.” No one knows them in this distinct manner, and without the possibility of mistake, except God alone. But it is to be able to say of a visible society, “Under this ministry and in this communion, God preserves and raises up the truly faithful.” As soon as we can form

Their lives with their Pretences well agree”. See his “Epistle to Eupolis” (1695), British Library Add. MS. 8888, p. 207. Later “Lockeans”, including John Toland and Anthony Collins, moved further in the same direction, disclaiming any necessity for churches on the assumption that everything that was needful for salvation was known to all through the natural faculty of reason. For the ensuing controversy see Robert E. Sullivan, *John Toland and the Deist Controversy: A Study in Adaptations* (Harvard University Press, 1982). Henry Longueville Mansel, “Freethinking—its history and tendencies”, in *Letters, Lectures, and Reviews*, ed. Henry W. Chandler (John Murray, 1873), 293–336, also continues to repay attention.

134 MS. Locke d. 10, p. 43 [“Ecclesia”, 1682].

this judgment with soundness and truth, we can also say, without the possibility of mistake, that it is a true visible Church.¹³⁵

A similar position would also be articulated by Philippus van Limborch, professor of theology at the Remonstrant seminary in Amsterdam, whom Locke had met and befriended in the winter of 1683–4. “The duty of church members, or the faithful,” Limborch wrote,

consists of several particulars. First amongst these is to gather together as a corporate group to glorify God and to bear witness to the progress of their faith: because He is to be glorified not only with the heart, but also in word and in deed, since both body and soul were created and redeemed by Him for His own ornament... This point must be marked well against those who, deprecating outward worship, believe that God is sufficiently worshipped with the heart and soul alone and that external profession may be omitted... as being not essential to religion.¹³⁶

135 Bodleian Library, MS. Locke d. 1, p. 85 [“Ecclesia visibilis”, 1679]: “La visibilité d’une vraye Eglise a nostre egard n’est pas de pouvoir dire destinctement et avec certitude. Voilà les vrays fideles de Jesus Christ. Personne ne les connoit de cette maniere distincte et sans s’y pouvoir tromper que Dieu seul. Mais c’est de pouvoir dire d’une société visible. Sous ce ministere et dans cette communion Dieu conserve et eleve des vrays fideles. Des qu’on peut former ce jugement avec solidité et verité, on peut dire aussi sans s’y tromper, que c’est une vraye Eglise visible.” Translation mine.

136 Philippus van Limborch, *Theologia Christiana ad Praxin Pietatis ac Promotionem Pacis Christianae Unice Directa* (Amsterdam, 1686), book 7, ch. 17, sections 1–2, 867–68: “officium Ecclesiae membrorum, seu fidelium... multiplex est. Ac primum quidem, in coetus ad Dei gloriam convocatos convenire, ibique fidei suae profellionem testari: quia Deus non tantum corde, sed & ore & opere est glorificandus: cum tam corpus quam anima ad honorem Dei sit conditum ac redemptum... Quod observandum contra eos, qui externum hunc cultum extenuant, sufficere credunt Deum corde ac animo coli; cor enim Deum proprie respicere; externam autem hanc professionem, utpote religioni non essentialem... omitti.” Translation mine. Subsequent editions have “fidei suae professionem testari,” i.e. bear witness to the profession of their faith. Locke read Limborch’s work in manuscript at around the time that he began the *Epistola*. See Locke, *Epistola*, xvi–xvii. A fuller comparison between Limborch’s text and Locke’s is provided in Luisa Simonutti, “Political Society and Religious Liberty. Locke at Cleves and in Holland,” *British Journal for the History of Philosophy* 14 (2006): 413–436, at 425–8.

Ironically, however, the position was stated most succinctly in the very text in which Locke is supposed to have declared that true and saving religion *consisted* in an inward persuasion of the mind, the *Letter concerning Toleration* that he had dedicated to Limborch:¹³⁷

Human beings, endowed with this liberty, must therefore enter some church, not only for mutual edification, but also to witness in the public presence that they are worshippers of God and offer such service as does not shame them, which they do not think unworthy or unacceptable to God, in order, by purity of teaching, holiness of life, and rites of unpompous decorum, that they may encourage in others love of religion and truth and may present such other things as cannot be done by an individual privately.¹³⁸

Locke, then, saw the public worship of God as a certain duty, prescribed by natural law, reiterated by Christianity, and necessary for all. Religion, while in *some* respects inward, being a matter of heart and soul as well as body, was neither private nor optional. It was a matter of natural duty rather than individual right or preference. It involved far more than persuasion of the mind, not least the duties to worship in corporate groups and to conduct one's life in accordance with natural law.

137 See Locke, *Epistola*, xviii–xx. Limborch returned the compliment by recognizing that the *Epistola* demonstrated its case by “religionis genio, et juri naturæ,” that is, the nature of religion and the law of nature. See Philippus van Limborch to Locke, 26 April 1689, no. 1131, in Locke, *Correspondence*, 3:608. The consequences of this point for understanding Locke's argument are elucidated in Ian Harris, “John Locke and Natural Law: Free Worship and Toleration”, in *Natural Law and Toleration in the Early Enlightenment*, ed. Jon Parkin and Timothy Stanton (Oxford University Press for the British Academy, 2013), 59–105.

138 Locke, *Epistola*, 100: “Hominibus itaque in ea libertate constitutis ineunda est societas ecclesiastica, ut coetus celebrant, non solum ad mutuam aedificationem, sed etiam ut se coram populo testentur cultores esse Dei, eumque se divino numini cultum offerre, cujus ipsos non pudet, nec Deo credunt aut indignum aut ingratum; ut doctrinae puritate, vitae sanctimonia et rituum modesto decore, alios ad religionis veritatisque amorem pelliceant aliaque praestent quae a singulis privatim fieri non possunt.”

If the proper manner of executing these duties called for judgment on the part of every one, and judgment produced probable opinion, Locke did not suppose for a second that all religious claims stood on an equal footing as “mere opinions.”¹³⁹ He knew that “there is truth opposite to falshood, that it may be found if people will, and is worth the seeking” and he judged it “not only the most valuable, but the pleasantest thing in the world.”¹⁴⁰

IV. IMPLICATIONS

The truth about true and saving religion takes us to a new paradigm for understanding Locke. The prevalent view of his position in effect extends to religion “the individualist postulate” that every man “is naturally the sole proprietor”—indeed the “absolute proprietor”—of “his own person and capacities.”¹⁴¹ The assumption is that in religion we exercise those capacities to “arrive on our own at certain ‘inward persuasions of the mind’” and may then perhaps “opt to seek out like-minded individuals with whom to join in creating a church”—a “paper thin” conception with no place for grace.¹⁴²

This position is not Locke’s. Genuine faith is not simply a product of “the individual’s own examination and insight;”¹⁴³ the faithful are those “who relye upon God and his promise of grace and not upon their own performances.”¹⁴⁴ Neither is church membership discretionary. It is integral to the practice of true religion. A church is the place within which faith is received and lived. Every one has a duty to join “that Church wherein he thinks is the truest

139 Kirstie M. McClure, “Difference, Diversity, and the Limits of Toleration,” *Political Theory* 18 (1990), 361–391, at 373.

140 Locke to William Molyneux, 10 January 1698, letter no. 2376, in Locke, *Correspondence*, 6:294.

141 C. B. Macpherson, *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism: Hobbes to Locke* (Clarendon Press, 1962), 231.

142 See Herdt, “Disciplinary Power of the Church,” 19; 27–8; 31.

143 Rainer Forst, *Toleration in Conflict: Past and Present* (Cambridge University Press, 2013), 218.

144 Locke, *Paraphrase*, 1:136. A point earlier underlined in *A Second Letter*, 18, which deploys the description of Jesus offered in Hebrews 12: 2, the “Author and Finisher of our Faith.”

worship of God, the greatest purity of truth & the best meanes of his edification, for his embracing this religion being for the salvation of his soul, he cannot reasonably but apply himself to that society where he thinks the things above mentiond are to be found.”¹⁴⁵

Again, this is not the language of someone for whom religion is optional and freedom of religion simply means freedom of opinion or thought. Locke assumes, on the contrary, that churches play a vital role in regulating people’s lives in accordance with virtue and piety, bringing to fullness a faith which worketh not by force, but by love, and by these means winning eternal salvation for their members.¹⁴⁶

These assumptions rarely figure in modern interpretations of Locke. The idea that he construed religion as a purely personal matter of individual conviction pervades the academic literature and informed opinion alike. In consequence it has seemed natural to cast Locke as a spokesman for liberalism and the liberal insistence that religion is a private affair and, in the process, to recast him in the image of liberalism and its religion.

Accordingly we are confronted with a Locke who equated “the private and the public” with “the internal and external.”¹⁴⁷ This Locke redefined religion as “something inward,”¹⁴⁸ “a purely internal matter, an affair of the soul and not of the body.”¹⁴⁹ Little wonder, then, that he is also said to have limited the sphere of religion “to the purely personal, internal, and

145 MS. Locke c. 34, 23.

146 Locke, *Epistola*, 58, alluding to Gal. 5: 6.

147 Duncan Kelly, *The Propriety of Liberty: Persons, Passions, and Judgement in Modern Political Thought* (Princeton University Press, 2011), 38.

148 Manfred Svensson, “Fundamental Doctrines of the Faith, Fundamental Doctrines of Society: Seventeenth-Century Doctrinal Minimalism,” *The Journal of Religion* 94 (2014): 161–181, at 180.

149 William T. Cavanaugh, “The City: Beyond Secular Parodies,” in *Radical Orthodoxy*, ed. John Milbank, Catherine Pickstock, and Graham Ward (Routledge, 1999), 182–200, at 190.

otherworldly,”¹⁵⁰ and to have “maintained a strong, normative preference for individual, interior religion”¹⁵¹ or an “inwardly oriented view of religion”¹⁵² because the position being attributed to him is the one that the postulate embodies: that “religious belief and action” by definition “are inward and private.”¹⁵³

Apparently this position led Locke to “portray the inner and private realm of individual worship as the nucleus and foundation of his conception of religion.”¹⁵⁴ It is a short step to the assertion that he understood religious worship to be “essentially a private matter,”¹⁵⁵ that, for him, “religious worship was...a private affair of the individual.”¹⁵⁶ All of this “is perfectly consistent with his radical individualism”¹⁵⁷ because Locke famously insisted upon “the essential privacy of each man’s thoughts.”¹⁵⁸ This line of reasoning culminates in the arresting claim that Locke’s “view of the nature of being religious...is completely individualistic,”¹⁵⁹ a claim that finds its complement in the assumption that with Locke being religious is almost entirely a matter of acquiring or assenting to certain beliefs¹⁶⁰ and the subsequent identification of freedom of religion with “freedom of thought.”¹⁶¹

150 Theodore J. Koontz, “Religion and Political Cohesion: John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau”, *Journal of Church and State* 23 (1981): 95–115, at 98.

151 Jeffrey R. Collins, “The Early Modern Foundations of Classic Liberalism,” in *The Oxford Handbook of the History of Political Philosophy*, ed. George Klosko (Oxford University Press, 2011), 258–81, at 278–79.

152 Martin Sutherland, *Peace, Toleration, and Decay: The Ecclesiology of Late Stuart Dissent* (Paternoster, 2003), 107.

153 David C. Snyder, “John Locke and the Freedom of Belief,” *Journal of Church and State* 30 (1988), 227–43, at 241.

154 Vered Sakal, “Two Conceptions of Religious Self in Lockean Religiosity,” *The Journal of Religion* 96 (2016), 332–45, at 333.

155 Milton and Milton in Locke, *Essay concerning Toleration*, 32.

156 John Marshall, *John Locke, Toleration and Early Enlightenment Culture* (Cambridge University Press, 2006), 538.

157 Denis Lacorne, *The Limits of Tolerance: Enlightenment Values and Religious Fanaticism* (Columbia University Press, 2019), 18.

158 George Windstrup, “Freedom and Authority: The Ancient Faith of Locke’s ‘Letter on Toleration’,” *The Review of Politics* 44 (1982), 242–65, at 246.

159 Kateb, “Locke and the Political Origins of Secularism,” 1017.

160 Kateb, “Locke and the Political Origins of Secularism,” 1021–2.

161 Lacorne, *The Limits of Tolerance*, 19.

Allegedly these conclusions are corroborated by a second, overlapping sequence of argument, which relates the private and the public to the soul—or mind—and the body respectively.

This sequence begins with the claim that Locke presupposed a dichotomy between the material and the immaterial,¹⁶² which he deployed to “activate parallel discursive separations between thought and action, divine and civil obligation, religious faith and political obedience.”¹⁶³ This meant “relegating” religion “to the immaterial and spiritual realm”—perhaps as part of a protracted plot to substitute “the private” in place of “the spiritual.”¹⁶⁴ Consequently religion reduces to “a matter of internal, psychological conviction.”¹⁶⁵

If “inner conviction animate[s] honest belief,”¹⁶⁶ it follows that “[a]ny sincere person’s subjectivity is closer to God than any uniform prescribed dogma,”¹⁶⁷ indicating that sincere (or “honest”) belief mattered as much or more to Locke than did true belief¹⁶⁸—so much so that he could “equate religious orthodoxy with sincerity of belief regardless of its content.”¹⁶⁹ Here, again, it is a short step to the claim that “Locke is saying that subjective belief makes a doctrine objectively true or false” and that, as a result, “sincere belief becomes the sufficient test of a doctrine’s truth and sincerity in one’s own beliefs is sufficient for salvation.”¹⁷⁰

162 Creston Davis and Clayton Crockett, “The Political and the Infinite,” *Angelaki: Journal of Theoretical Humanities* 12 (2007): 1–10, at 1.

163 McClure, “Difference, Diversity, and the Limits of Toleration,” 372.

164 Snyder, “John Locke and the Freedom of Belief,” 241, states that Locke “remakes” the “secular/sacred, reason/faith dichotomy into an outer/inner, public/ private one.”

165 Richard J. Regan, *The American Constitution and Religion* (Catholic University of America Press, 2013), 255.

166 Jeffrey R. Collins, *In the Shadow of Leviathan: John Locke and the Politics of Conscience* (Cambridge University Press, 2020), 256.

167 Kateb, “Locke and the Political Origins of Secularism,” 1022.

168 Bou-Habib, “Locke, Sincerity and the Rationality of Persecution,” 622–23. See also Michael A. Helfland, “A Liberalism of Sincerity: The Role of Religion in the Public Square,” *Journal of Law, Religion & State* 1 (2012): 217–241 and Perez Zagorin, “Religious Toleration,” in *The Oxford Handbook of the History of Political Philosophy*, ed. Klosko, 689–700, at 698, where it is said that Locke emphasized “the primacy of subjective conscientious conviction in everything to do with religion.”

169 Sanford Kessler, “John Locke’s Legacy of Religious Freedom,” *Polity* 17 (1985): 484–503, at 492.

170 Robert P. Kraynak, “John Locke: From Absolutism to Toleration,” *American Political Science Review* 74 (1980): 53–68, at 65.

Such reasoning is supposed to have received ratification from an unimpeachable source, for, as we have seen, Christ himself had revealed that, with his coming, “To be Worshipped in Spirit and in Truth;” meaning “with application of Mind and sincerity of Heart, was what God henceforth only required,”¹⁷¹ thus indicating that belonging to a church was unnecessary to salvation.¹⁷² Perhaps this was Popple’s position. It was certainly not Locke’s.

Conversely one sees why that position has so often been attributed to Locke, because it can be construed as a direct implication of the postulate. If “true and saving Religion consists in an inward perswasion of the Mind”, salvation is procured by inward persuasion alone. Inward persuasion is faith, faith being “nothing but a firm Assent of the Mind,”¹⁷³ something that “belongs to the individual’s own irreducible singularity and inwardness of mind.”¹⁷⁴ Ergo faith or belief alone saves. Nothing else is relevant. Nothing more is required. Ergo “churches are not an essential part” of Christianity.¹⁷⁵

Locke is identified in turn as someone who disavowed the need for Christianity “to be embodied in a community.”¹⁷⁶ All that matters is that “we endeavour to reason about our salvation, so that our assent to a set of religious beliefs represents our sincere conviction.”¹⁷⁷

171 See notes 114 and 115 above.

172 Diego Lucci, “Political Scepticism, Moral Scepticism, and the Scope and Limits of Toleration in John Locke,” *Yearbook of the Maimonides Centre for Advanced Studies* 3 (2018): 109–43, at 135–36.

173 Locke, *An Essay*, IV.xvii.24, 687, cited by Steven J. Heyman, “The Light of Nature: John Locke, Natural Rights, and the Origins of American Religious Liberty,” *Marquette Law Review* 101 (2018): 705–74, at 745, prefacing the claim that salvation is secured by an act of believing, a claim supported by the invocation of the postulate (at 749).

174 Davis and Crockett, “The Political and the Infinite,” 3. Again the postulate is cited in support of this conclusion.

175 Monserrat Herrero, “The Quest for Locke’s Political Theology,” *Etica & Politica / Ethics & Politics* 18, (2016): 83–109, at 95–96. Compare Cavanaugh, “A Fire”, 399: Because “the Christian is saved by faith alone, the Church...become[s], strictly speaking, unnecessary for salvation.”

176 Sarah Mortimer, “Religion and Enlightenment,” in *A Companion to Intellectual History*, ed. Richard Whatmore and Brian Young (Wiley Blackwell, 2016), 345–57, at 350.

177 Peter C. Myers, “Locke on Reasonable Christianity and Reasonable Politics,” in *Piety and Humanity: Essays on Religion and Early Modern Philosophy*, ed. Douglas Kries (Lexington Books, 1997), 145–180, at 149, with this claim substantiated by reference to the postulate.

Faith is one of the names given to the results of such reasoning. Opinion is another. Locke says the two are equivalent: that is why, for him, “matters of religious faith fall into the realm of opinion”¹⁷⁸ and why the late J. G. A. Pocock could find in his philosophy the fountainhead of “that all important change, in which religious freedom becomes freedom of religion and, in ceasing to be the freedom of the Spirit, becomes the freedom of reason and opinion.”¹⁷⁹ Neither could it be otherwise if religion itself was simply a matter of opinion—as it must be if “true and saving Religion consists in an inward perswasion of the Mind.”

Thus, like an Escher stairway, each of these sequences of reasoning ends where it begins and begins where it ends: with Locke’s postulate. Each proceeds on premises extracted from the postulate and arrives at conclusions that illustrate and validate those premises with reference to the postulate.¹⁸⁰ The result is a structure of reasoning that is entirely self-referential and self-sustaining. There is the illusion of an ascent from first principles to final ends but in reality we are going round in a circle in which the religion of Locke has already metamorphosed imperceptibly into the religion of liberalism.

This article has demonstrated that this improbable structure is radically insecure and unsound. An unavoidably negative implication is that the vast majority of contemporary analyses of Locke’s views of religion, religious freedom, and toleration which take their cue from Popple’s translation of the *Letter* and which fix Locke in a liberal mold are built upon a false

178 Shelley Weinberg, “Locke’s Natural and Religious Epistemology,” *Journal of the History of Philosophy* 58 (2020): 241–266, at 244, citing Locke, *An Essay*, I.i.3, 44, where “Faith, or Opinion” is defined as “that Assent, which we give to any Proposition as true, of whose Truth yet we have no certain Knowledge.”

179 J. G. A. Pocock, “Religious Freedom and the Desacralization of Politics: From the English Civil Wars to the Virginia Statute,” in *The Virginia Statute for Religious Freedom: Its Evolution and Consequences in American History*, ed. Merrill D. Peterson and Robert C. Vaughan (Cambridge University Press, 2008), 43–73, at 54.

180 In addition to the instances already cited, the postulate or its corollary is invoked in support of claims about Locke’s premises and conclusions in the named works by Bou-Habib (615 and 620), Forst (220), Kateb (1021), Kessler (491–92), Kraynak (65), Lacorne (19), Regan (252), Snyder (233 and 237), Sutherland (107) and Zagorin (688–89).

foundation and require significant revision.¹⁸¹

A more positive effect is that escaping the circle opens new ways of looking at Locke. It becomes possible to see that his own view of true and saving religion scarcely resembles the prevalent view at all. Locke used natural theology as a postulate in thinking about the institutional and practical implications of a duty of collective public worship that was known by natural reason and universally obligatory. He used the contents of Christian revelation to refine and extend his thinking in terms that gave Christian churches a uniquely privileged position in the economy of salvation: They are at once communities of love and guardians of truth, animated by hopes of immortality and nourished by the grace of the Holy Spirit who is the Spirit of Truth.¹⁸²

It is the work of churches to bear witness to that truth, to edify their own members, and to teach charity, meekness, and toleration to all mankind,¹⁸³ members and non-members, Christians and non-Christians alike—for a church “judgeth not them that are without.”¹⁸⁴ They are at the same time missionary organizations, charged with preaching the Word to the whole world and by that means, and that means alone, enlarging the kingdom of God after the manner of the “Prince of peace, who sent out his disciples to subdue the nations and grow the church armed not with weapons, nor the sword, nor with force of arms, but with the Gospel, the message of peace, and the exemplary sanctity of their conduct.”¹⁸⁵

181 An implication explored in other directions in Timothy Stanton, “John Locke and the Fable of Liberalism,” *Historical Journal* 61 (2018): 597–622, esp. 610–616. The hazards of relying on Popple’s translation of the *Epistola* are noted briefly in the postscript to J. R. Milton, “Locke, *Numen*, and the Toleration of Atheism,” *History of Political Thought* 43 (2022): 714–728, at 728.

182 See John 14:17.

183 Locke, *Epistola*, 86–8, alluding to Luke 2: 14.

184 Locke, *Epistola*, 144/45, citing 1 Cor. 5: 12–13.

185 Locke, *Epistola*, 64, echoing 1 Tim. 2: 1–4; Titus 3: 8; Eph. 4: 28; and Gal. 6: 9: “...principis pacis sequerentur exemplum, qui satellites suos non ferro, non gladio, non vi armatos, sed Evangelio, sed pacis nuntio, morum sanctitate et exemplo instructos, ad subjugandas gentes et in ecclesiam cogendas emisit.”

V. CONCLUSION

For many decades now it has been customary to treat Locke as a “distinguished ancestor” and architect of the “liberal individualism” which, in the monitory judgment of Alasdair MacIntyre, embodies the ethos of a “distinctively modern and modernizing world” unremittingly hostile to the notion that the “best type of human life... is lived by those engaged in constructing and sustaining forms of community directed towards the shared achievement of those common goods without which the ultimate human good cannot be achieved.”¹⁸⁶ Having displaced the postulate from its previously unquestioned position, this treatment is no longer tenable. Locke rejected the idea that human beings naturally stand to one another as passing strangers and have no need to enter into those relationships which constitute communities whose central bond is a shared vision and understanding of such goods.¹⁸⁷ He theorized and valorized a liberty that searched for love and truth in pursuit of the end he regarded as the most important one of all for every single human being and found both in the churches of their own choosing. In this respect his prepossessions were not those of subsequent liberal political theory but rather those of another—doubtless very different—St. Paul.

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186 Alasdair MacIntyre, *After Virtue: A Study in Moral Theory*, third edition (University of Notre Dame Press, 2007), 250 [“Th[e] individualistic view has a distinguished ancestry: Hobbes, Locke... and others.”]; xviii; xiv. The exception that proves the rule is John Dunn, *The Political Thought of John Locke: An Historical Account of the Argument of the ‘Two Treatises of Government’* (Cambridge University Press, 1969).

187 MacIntyre, *After Virtue*, 251 and 258.